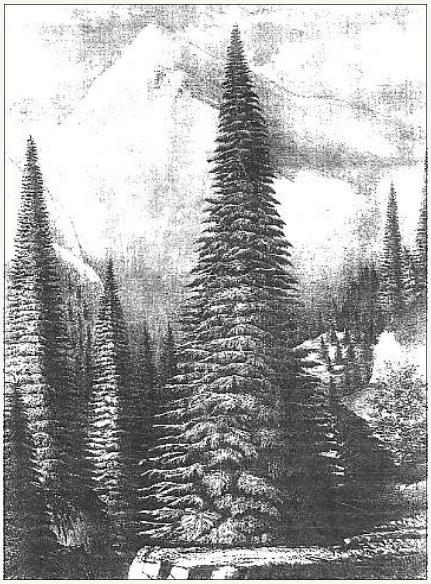
Volume 2 Issue 3 Winter 2008

Hollerbeier Haven

Newsletter for the Herbal and Healing Arts



CONTENTS

The New Arrival	2
Celebrate the Mundane	3
The Unsung Hero	4
Geometric Teachings	6
The Third Rune– Thorn	7
Urglaawe-The Original Faith	8
The 12 Days of Christmas	9
Four Humors Medicine	10
Sage– Salwei	11
Sacred Agreements	14
Blatant Advertising	18 -19

Happy Holidays to all!

If nothing else, this is a season of big changes! All around there are waves of change and transformation lapping at the edges of our lives!

We are expecting a change in president in the very near future. Though we cannot predict the future, we pray that our new president-elect will lead us well and to a peaceful and sustainable future.

In the world of the Kutzeschteddel Raad (Kutztown Wheel), we have added two new apprentices to our circle, and there may be more still this year. Annie Hasz is presently enrolled in the Braucherei Weg course, and has been studying various aspects of traditional medicine through Prescott College's Adult Degree Program. Rob Lusch is also currently taking the Braucherei Weg course and his particular focus tends toward the study of Urglaawe or "original faith". In addition to this, Rob has been helping us in our attempts to create community Deitsch language courses, acting as facilitator and sometimes instructor of our weekly discussion group. You will be seeing and hearing much more from all members of our Raad in the upcoming year, as big changes are coming to the guild gatherings and newsletter as well.

On October 30, Jesse and Matthew welcomed a new child into their lives. As you would expect, this will be transforming Jesse's teaching schedule a bit. In 2009 Jesse will only be teaching 3 Guild meetings, though her schedule of teaching Der Braucherei Weg will go on, uninterrupted.

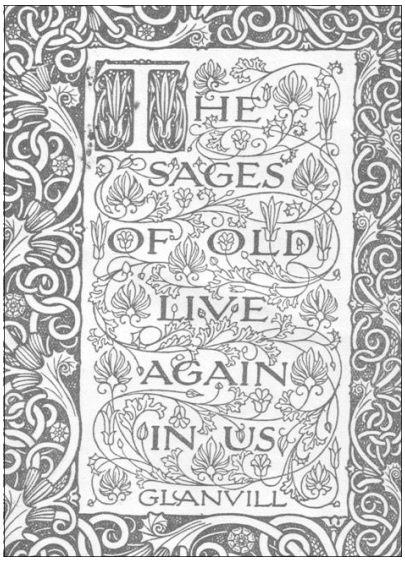
In addition to Jesse, all of the other members of the Kutzeschteddel Raad will be teaching some new guild meetings. We are all very excited to see what comes of these new topics and new faces. We will still cover some things that we have discussed before: the Wheel of the Year, Hex Signs, Blanzeschwetze, etc. But we will also be delving into some new areas: Urglaawe, Folkloric Herbal Medicine, Sympathies, etc. It should be an interesting and exciting year.



All of our Raad members will also be contributing more regularly to the newsletter as well. It is so exciting for Matthew, Susan, and I to watch our circle grow!!! Now we have enough people intimately involved in this subject that there are multiple perspectives coming together to create a real diversity of voices in this movement of revival!

We hope this time of deepening and renewal finds all of you well. Happy Holidays to all, and May the New Year bring you abundant good health !

Blessings, Jesse and Susan



The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

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Elijah Finn Sicher

Born October 30th, 2008

7lbs. 7 oz. 19.5 inches long

"...everyone is a hero at birth, where he undergoes a tremendous psychological as well as physical transformation, from the condition of a little water creature living in the realm of amniotic fluid into an air breathing mammal which will ultimately be standing. That's an enormous transformation...indeed, a heroic act."

Joseph Campbell

Celebrate the Mundane by Jesse Tobin



In modern western, and in particular, American culture we seem to hold to the notion that bigger is better. If a little bit is good, even more must be great! Our lives have never in history been so full of stimulation. In work, play, and relaxation our days are full of electronic media, advertising, and gobs of material wealth. We live in a state of constant news and updates. We are so plugged in to the commercial and media worlds that it is difficult to find time for simple tasks like cooking healthy, quality food for our families, sitting down to eat together, or reading a story to a child at bedtime. We rush through our lives as though everything is a chore, eager to find this so-called "leisure time" that the convenience of our modern lives are supposed to afford us.

All of this convenience, all this wealth, flashiness and grandeur has been marketed to us well, and the vast majority of Americans have taken it all: hook, line, and sinker. But does the reality of this new world look anything like it did in the brochure? I recently read a book called *The Geography of Bliss* by Eric Weiner. In the book, Weiner takes a closer look at the happiness studies of people from around the world. He finds unhappiness in some likely places: many impoverished and maldeveloped nations, but he also finds it in some of the wealthiest countries in the world: places like Qatar, a nation in which there are no taxes or utility bills, and in which all citizens receive a government issued stipend for living expenses. Similarly, the happiest places in the world included countries as different as Iceland, Switzerland, and Bhutan.

In all of these happy places a few things were held in common: it is apparent to all of these cultures that competition over material wealth is at the root of many of the ills of society. In Bhutan the way to solve the problem is easy: there is no competition because there is no option for extreme wealth. Everyone is pretty much on the same level, life is slow, community is important. In places like Switzerland and Iceland there is a different way to deal with this issue: make sure everyone's needs are met, and live simply. Among the Swiss especially, the notion of showing off one's wealth is absolutely taboo. It is a country of millionaires who drive beat-up Volvos.

Most important to all of these people was their understanding of the nature of happiness. Does happiness mean a constant state of stimulation and elation? Not to the citizens of the happiest countries in the world. To them it means quiet contentedness. Contentedness is a concept that is almost as foreign to the average modern American as the Icelandic language itself, and it is certainly not equated to happiness in the American mindset. Our culture was founded by pioneers, entrepreneurs, and visionaries. In the founding and building of America there has scarcely been time to rest, and we are always driven forward by the need to compete, to grow, to move forward faster. But is this idea the ideal? Where are we going, anyway, that we are driving so fast and competitively to get to first? At the end of our long lives, is it really more important that our bank accounts are huge, our homes extravagantly furnished, and our driveways filled with the most expensive and flashy cars? What about our families? Our communities? Our day-to-day lives?

Continued on page 5...

The Unsung Hero by Jesse Tobin

What is a Hero? Who is a role model? Whose words should be kept for posterity? Whose actions could be called legendary? It is an easy thing to idolize the famous people of our time, and of history. It is simple and emotionally undemanding to put a great thinker, leader, or musician on a pedestal. These people are elevated above society by their obvious gifts, their drive to lead, or sometimes even by luck. They ride above the fates of the masses, and seem to avoid the humdrum existence of common people.

Yes, to mark such a great person as a hero is easy, the name and deeds well documented and recognizable to others, their contributions unquestionable. But theirs is not always the fullest well to draw from. There are many millions of people whose stories, trials, and deeds of glory well up from the soil of the earth, and beg to be known.

Great organizers like Mother Jones and Joe Hill go down in history with honor and infamy, but what of the millions of common workers who suffered pain of body and of soul, and some who gave their lives to benefit their unknown descendents of generations to come? Who knows the story of the steelworker who had to send his children to relatives or union sympathizers to ensure their safety and sustenance? Who remembers the mill girl whose life expired from unsafe conditions before she had the chance to fall in love? Who tells of the boy crushed in the coalmines of West Virginia before he reached manhood?

Even more recently, it is easy to honor the work of Martin Luther King, Jr. It is the people who moved beneath his words, however, who changed the realities of our country. It is these people who suffered violence and prison, who walked through hostility and kept on walking, always forward, toward a new day. Rachel Carson told a story, but it took millions of voices to change the law. It is these voices that whispered and shouted, and set themselves to work. It is these hands and minds, which birthed the movement toward sustainability.

These are the heroes of everyday. These are the ones that really matter. These are the hands that turn the wheels and cogs of the world, the ones who truly possess the power to change the flow of history. No revolution has ever succeeded without the hands of the common man and woman. No movement has transformed society without their consent. Conversely, when these heroes decide that change is on its way, it comes. There is no government, no military, no church in the world that could ever stem the tide of such a movement of people.

There have been many who tried to put down such movements by force. They can delay such tides, put off their truths, suppress their memories, but they cannot extinguish the fire and passion of men and women, mothers and fathers, sisters and brothers, husbands and wives. Even when such a flame seems to have been utterly extinguished, the embers hide beneath the ash and wait for the winds to shift, for new fuel to come. The passion of Spirit continues always.

There are many to be honored at the feast of Alleliebeziel: saints and prophets, sprits, gods of old, the recently departed. How many, though, are forgotten on this high day of remembrance? Next Halloween I entreat you all to learn the name and story of just one of your many ancestors. Learn of their family, their work, and their passion. Learn of their birth and death. Most importantly, remember these old ones who are gone in your prayers and at your feasts on this day. Write their stories down and share them among your family, keep them for your children. Begin a treasury of Halloween stories that have nothing to do with ghosts, goblins, and fearful things, and everything to do with the spirits of your ancestry.

It is important to remember this at a time when we prepare for the inauguration of our next national leader: it is not the leader who decides the course of our nation, our people, our history. It is you and I. Sharing the stories of the common men and women of your own family will give you and your children the wealth of heroes they will need to inspire them in the challenging times to come. May the guiding hands of these ancestors steer us clear of rocks in the storms that approach, may they be a guiding light through the tumult, and bring us to safe harbor. May we all devote ourselves to the practice of becoming the best ancestors we can be, and create a world of peace and prosperity for all. AMEN + + +

Celebrate the Mundane continued from page 3...

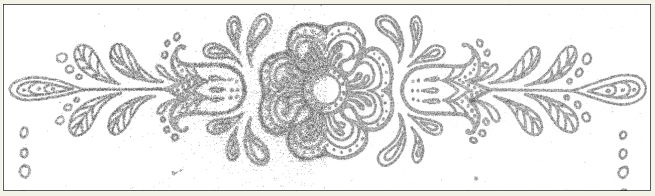
Learning what I have about Braucherei and traditional living, a whole world of understanding has opened up for me. It seems to be one that has been entirely forgotten in the wider world. Traditional wisdom has taught me many things, but most important, I think, is how to be content with the life I am living today. Through Braucherei I have learned to turn housecleaning, laundry, and food making into a daily and weekly ceremony of life. I have learned to rejoice in the daily company of my family and surrounding community, cherishing time spent in shared meal preparation, games, and simple discussion.

No where in Braucherei tradition does this wisdom of simplicity shine through more clearly than in the traditions, ceremonies, and beliefs of the Wheel of the Year. The wheel teaches us that prayer, magic, and daily life are not separate, and that our tendency to break them into separate pieces within our lives shows an incomplete understanding of the very nature of spirit. It has been said by spiritual leaders from Thich Nhat Hanh, and the Dali Llama, to Mother Theresa and Jacob Boehme: when life is lived intentionally, every breath is a prayer. There is no beginning or end to our daily relationship with God. We are not with God only when we are at church or when we pray for a friend in need. Spirit is present in every moment, but it is our choice also in every moment of life: to join hands and walk in harmony, or to live our lives in isolation and pain.

To an old time Braucherin sweeping the floor was a physical prayer, preparing a meal an act of magic, wild crafting for berries communion with God. This is the aspect of Braucherei path that no elder can teach, except by example. Each child of the earth must find their own way in their path to wholeness.

The Wheel of the Year teaches us that plowing, planting, weeding, harvesting, and feasting can all be the physical actions of prayers that act on every level: not just physical, but mental, emotional, and spiritual as well. It shows us the importance of constant interaction with and support of our communities and families, both in good times and bad. Finally, it teaches us to move the patterns of our lives, as well as our acts of prayer and magic *along with* the flow of the seasons and the movements of nature, not *against* them.

Altogether the teachings present throughout Braucherei show us that although many aspects of daily life are mundane and patterned, they need not be boring burdens. One thing stands out throughout everything I have learned, and that is that attitude is everything. Every toilsome aspect of life can be looked at as an obstacle, a challenge, or an opportunity for growth toward wholeness; all we must do is choose to walk the path of intention.



From 'Beliefs and Superstitions of the Pennsylvania Germans' (1915) by Edwin Miller Fogel, Ph.D.

Uff Neiyaarmarye
soll mer'n Brotwarschi
esse, so as mer's Yaahr
schtarick un grefdich iss.

Translation to be found somewhere within the pages of this newsletter!!



Geometric Teachings

by Lauren Sicher

Hex or barn signs frequent the broad canvas of southeastern Pennsylvania and beyond, flickering across the country and even throughout the world. They consist of familiar geometric images, flowers, and animals in repeating patterns. Although in the past the signs held greater meaning and importance, in our era they are most often seen being sold as souvenirs in various sizes, or painted directly on barns. In modern times they are generally thought of as something aesthetically pleasing and little more. In the past, however, hex signs were used as talismans, charms, decorations, and "visual prayers" by Brauchers and lay people alike.

Among the interviews collected by Dennis Boyer, was one of unique perspective in the understanding of hex signs. The man from Wisconsin shared his beliefs about what hex signs showed us and the knowledge they held. He believes that the geometric symbols depicted in hex signs, represent much more even than we had believed from the study of sacred geometry and Germanic symbolism. In his opinion the colorful and repeating patterns of the hex signs represent nothing less than the crystallized forms of "inorganic beings" of pure spirit. These beings he speaks of might be known to Brauchers as angels, earth spirits, elves, or even pre-Christian deities. Of course, he said, encountering such a being (in trance, prayer, or meditative state), one would see the being in three dimensions. His description of his encounters with them depicted them as crystalline forms of pure spirit. Naturally such an experience would be difficult to render into an image to share, but he believes hex signs to be the traditional way of doing so. Hex signs record such experiences and beings in the simplified, two-dimensional realm of folk art. This man said that hex signs are like a photograph: the picture can only represent an image, but never a full likeness of the three-dimensional being.

Although no one fully understands the purpose of these beings, our Wisconsin friend is sure that they come to us with teachings and energy to share. All one needs to do to come into contact with these beings of spirit is to request the teaching or knowledge. As in most aspects of Braucherei, the earnest thirst for healing or knowledge is all the exchange that is required. These spirits seem to be bound to the same code as we abide by on the Braucherei Path (or perhaps we abide by it as we have been taught by such spiritual beings!): whenever there is a sincere request for help we must dedicate ourselves to a path of healing and growth along side those in need.

The signs themselves are representative of the spirits. Because of this it is an act of honoring such a spirit, according to this man, to paint a certain sign. This act of honoring is one of the things that we humans can do in gratitude for the teachings we receive from the world of spirit. This is also a good reason to really spend time connecting with hex sign imagery before simply slapping a certain hex sign up on a barn or house. These signs may not be the simple images that most think of them as, but may hold truths deeper than we can imagine.

In addition to acting as representations of the inorganic beings, the Wisconsin man spoke of other teachings to be gleaned from hex signs in a more direct and tangible way. Teachings from these signs can help us understand the different energies that are present in our own bodies and the whole world that surrounds us. He shared his understanding that curved shapes tend to represent feminine (flower petals, circles, and crescents). In contrast, male energy is usually represented by the sharp and pointed shapes (suns and stars). Pointed or curved symbols don't always represent either male or female, they can also depict relationships between beings and natural forces, such as the relationships between fire, water, air, and land. The intent or essence behind the shapes and colors can also be felt as a hard energy being bold and assertive or a soft energy being comforting and nourishing. This feeling of energy, according to Dennis, varies between the symbols and is not necessarily bound to specific shapes. These symbols and images come to us as gifts of wisdom from spirit. Sometimes they are used for protective charms, healing images, or visual prayers for balance and harmony with the world that surrounds us. It must be remembered, though that they can also be reminders of what we need to observe or change in our lives.

So, next time you look at a geometric symbol, remember that it may be holding a deeper truth than is available to the superficial or even symbolic meaning. It is very possibly a message, a prayer, or a call for protection, so pay attention! Perhaps there is a symbol, which reoccurs in your life, or one that you are particularly drawn to. Next time this happens, stop, observe and take time to listen. What message are you hearing?

The Third Rune~ Thorn by Patrick Donmoyer

"The Thorn is very sharp to everyone,

Bad to take hold of,

Severe to those who rest among them."

-Anglo-Saxon Rune Poem

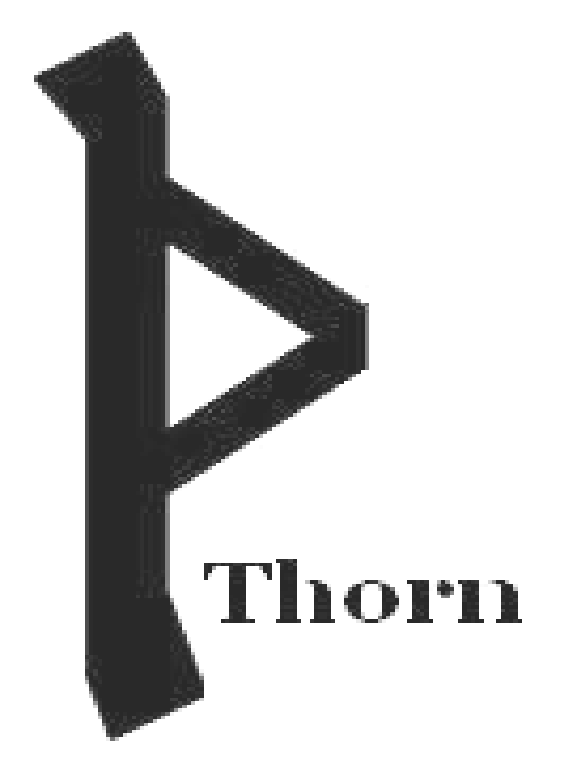
(Thomas Howard Translation)

The third Rune in the Anglo-Saxon order is called Thorn. In both the Norse and the Icelandic orders the rune is called Thurs, which literally means Giant. Although this rune has two possible linguistic associations, and therefore could create confusion between the runic systems, there remains a certain similarity in meaning. Both imply an imminent danger to a person bodily, and an obstacle to overcome. The contrast between the severity a thorn and the threat imposed by a giant could describe the scope of the potential danger that the rune implies. Both could be understood as a force of nature. This rune could also imply protection by means of that which can be dangerous to others, just as the rose is protected by its thorns. A perfect example of this can be found in Scottish symbolism, where the thistle, according to folklore, functioned to warn the Scots of an impending invasion from the Scandinavians. The barefooted Scandinavians dared to invade from the coast in the dead of night only to be stalled by a field of thistles. Their cries of pain woke the Scots, who drove off their Scandinavian invaders. Thus the Thistle is revered for its thorns.

This Rune has traditional correspondences to two different gods of the Germanic pantheon. The first is an indirect allusion to Loki, as he was the malevolent god presiding over the frost giants. A second association comes from a similarity in the rune's form to the shape of Thor's enchanted Hammer Miolnir. This connection is emphasized by the nearness of pronunciation in Thor to Thurs, although it must be noted that the words are not linguistically related. These two personae could describe the dual nature of the protective and threatening function of Thorn.

Again following in the spirit of Odin, whose interpretation of the runes is inextricably linked to the idea of spiritual transformation, this rune implies that how one responds to the danger is as important as understanding the nature itself. If the threat described by Thorn is great enough, it can represent a starting point for change.

Thorn's context within a casting will ultimately describe the nature of the threat, and what it portends. If Thorn is found in combination with an inverted Feoh for instance, it could indicate a threat to one's wealth and livelihood. However, if Thorn is found in combination with an upright Ur, it could indicate that the challenge will be well received. An inverted Thorn however could indicate that the querent is not ready for the challenge in question, and that the experience could be painful.



URGLAAWE by Rob Lusch

In recent months, many Heathen-related events have been seasoned with elements of Pennsylvania German culture. In fact, some rituals have been completely in the Pennsylvania German (Deitsch) language and have been a core part of some events conducted by the Philadelphia Area Asatru and Urglaawe Meetup Group.

So what is all this activity about? What exactly is Urglaawe?

Broken down and translated, "der Urglaawe" literally means "the original faith" in the Deitsch language. Urglaawe is a Heathen movement that focuses on the pre-Christian religious and cultural undertones that still flow through the Pennsylvania German culture. Although the Pennsylvania Germans did not exist as a distinct ethnic group during the pre-Christian era, our ancestors brought with them many Heathen practices that continued to flourish here after the Diaspora into the Americas.

Our purpose is to weave the cultural experiences of the Pennsylvania Germans into the Heathen tapestry. Healing and magical practices, such as Braucherei and Hexerei, as well as folklore and folk medicine will shed more light on the way our ancestors practiced their faith. Urglaawer (those who follow the faith) honor the same Gods and Goddesses as Asatruar, though our folklore and experiences may lead to recognition of wights or other entities known only to our ancestors. Examples of these include Die Weisskeppich Fraa (The White-Haired Woman) from Braucherei practice and Der Ewich Yeeger, who appears in most folk stories as a hero who ensured that the early Deitsch settlers had an ample food supply (Boyer).

Urglaawer face the same challenges as other Heathen groups when it comes to reconstructing the past. Fortunately, however, Braucherei and Hexerei are living traditions that have been passed down through the ages. Even with borrowings and influences from other religions and traditions, the Heathen roots show through in the form of the chants, superstitions, and symbols.

Braucherei was on the decline in recent decades with the advances of modern medicine. However, thanks to institutions such as the Three Sisters Center, a concerted effort is underway to educate interested people on the historical evolution of the tradition and to pass it on to future apprentices. Resources such as this are of incalculable value to Urglaawer as they give us the opportunity to connect with current practitioners and to access records of many who have passed on.

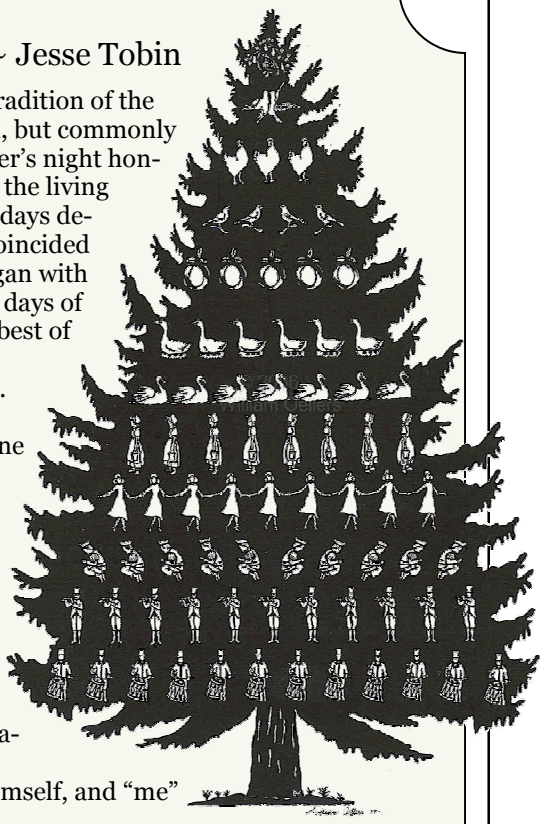
Hexerei, while generally practiced in small groups or individually, seems also to be experiencing resurgence in recent years. Although Wicca has influenced the development of Hexerei in some circumstances, many Urglaawer practitioners have been striving to research and restore, if possible, the spells and chants to a pre-Christian context. There is certainly some controversy regarding these efforts, as it is difficult to verify the results. However, there is value in their research, such as the sharing of old remedies and spells from older German texts.

Continued on page 17...



The Norse Goddess Frigg spinning the clouds by J.C. Dollman

The Twelve Days of Christmas~ Jesse Tobin



The Twelve Days of Christmas originated in the pre-Christian Germanic tradition of the Twelve days of Yule. The dates of the Yule celebration vary by year and region, but commonly the feast began the night before the winter solstice with Mother's night. Mother's night honored the female ancestral spirits of a family, along with various goddesses and the living mothers of the family. The feast of Yule continued after this night for 12 to 13 days depending on local tradition. In Christian times the feast was moved so that it coincided with Christmas. In Medieval Christmas tradition the feast and celebration began with Christmas Eve, and continued until Epiphany Day on January 6th. During the days of Christmas all work was laid aside and all people feasted and celebrated to the best of their means.

Our modern celebrations of Christmas barely do justice to the old ways. Nowadays we are lucky to have one day off from work, and spend much of our time in stressful travel, not in the warm environment of family and friends. One of our most beloved remembrances of the old Christmas is the carol: "The Twelve Days of Christmas". It is well known as a somewhat nonsensical song. On further research, however, the song reveled itself to have greater tradition behind it.

There is a legend that the song was anonymously penned during times of persecution of the Catholics in England. The words were written to the tune of an older 12 days song, which corresponded to a pre-Christian understanding of the Yule feast. According to this legend, the song was written to help children remember the tenets of their Catholic faith. In another version of the story, the song is a traditional continental song, with French or Scandinavian origins. Either way, it seems to have been a catechism song.

According to this understanding of the song, the "true love" was God Himself, and "me" was any baptized person.

The "partridge in a pear tree" was Christ (possibly a reference to Matt. 23:37 and Luke 13:34).

The "2 turtle doves" were the two Testaments of the Bible.

The "3 French hens" stood for the Theological Virtues: faith, hope and love. (1 Corinthians. 13)

The "4 calling birds" (originally the "4 Colly Birds", or blackbirds) referred to the four evangelists: Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, and their four gospels.

The "5 golden rings" (originally referring to ring-necked pheasants), recalled the five books of Moses in the old testament, also called the Law or Pentateuch: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers and Deuteronomy.

The "6 geese a laying" recalled the 6 days of creation.

The "7 swans a swimming" reminded children of the 7 gifts of the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians. 7:30) The 7 Sacraments of the Catholic Church: Baptism, Reconciliation, Eucharist, Confirmation, Marriage, Holy Orders, and Anointing of the Sick.

The "8 maids a milking" were the eight Beatitudes (Matt. 5-6):

Blessed are the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

Blessed are the meek: for they shall inherit the earth.

Blessed are they who mourn: for they shall be comforted.

Blessed are they that hunger and thirst after justice: for they shall have their fill.

Blessed are the merciful: for they shall obtain mercy.

Blessed are the clean of heart: for they shall see God.

Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God.

Blessed are they that suffer persecution for justice' sake, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

Continued on page 16...

Four Humors Medicine ~ Part 1 by Annie Hasz



Galen, Avicenna and Hippocrates, Canon of Medicine

Embalming the Living

The four humors disease etiology that informs the Braucherei healing tradition of the Pennsylvania Dutch has an ancient origin. Some uniting theory of etiology is part of the essential soul of a folk medical practice and is the foundation of a coherent system of therapy . The Galenic depiction of the four humors theory of pathenogenesis, which survives in Pennsylvania Dutch folk medicine, represents an attempt to manifest centuries of thought, discussion, and experiment in final form. Though the four humors doctrine as defined by Galen became canonical, holding sway in pockets of practice in our time as well as retroactively casting medical theory B.G. (*before Galen*) in its image, the true state of etiological understanding was much more complex and interesting, and continues to evolve in diverse ways in response to lessons of experience.

Galen: The Influence Examined

Before stepping out from Galen's shadow to dip into the ancient pool of knowledge from which our tradition came, it is worthwhile to appreciate the nature of Galen's influence. While he lived and breathed in the 2nd century AD, Galen's central project was the systematization of Greek medical knowledge. Galen was a philosopher doctor in the highest echelon of society whose systemization of medical ideas came to dominate practice in the Byzantium and the Muslim world and thoroughly permeated medieval and renaissance Europe. He was an unusually prominent, wealthy physician who doctored the emperor Marcus Aurelius in an era when most physicians in the Hippocratic tradition had the modest though respectable status of other craftsmen. Galen believed the physician was a superior craftsman and that it was appropriate for the doctor to have an elevated position in society . The son of a wealthy, doting father, he was the beneficiary of rigorous philosophical training and was spent ten years traveling the eastern Mediterranean visiting medical centers and studying. From Galen -- who once asserted that "the best physician is also a philosopher" -- we have inherited the notion that medicine is firstly a system of thought, a way of ordering the world .

Continued on page 12...



Garden Sage

Salvia officinalis

Salvia, Salwei

Garden Sage is a perennial shrub with a height of two feet and a width of two feet . The leaves are leathery in texture and greenish gray. The drier the weather during the growing season, the grayer the leaf. The plant flowers in June. A gentle pruning in late winter will keep the shrub tidy.

Traditional medicinal uses: Remedy for colds and flu; Great as a tea for a sore throat as a gargle, for strep throat, to dry up sinus secretions, mucus in the upper respiratory tract or as a carminitive for intestinal flu. Will cause a good sweat when taken as hot tea (think sauna or detox). Will stop sweating (night sweats, hot flashes) when taken as a cool tea. Use as a gargle for gingivitis or in a neti pot for sinus infections. A very old PA German (and Polish) remedy suggests that eating three sage leaves daily in the morning with breakfast will protect one from all forms of contagion met throughout the day. Several references suggest combining sage with mullein leaf and infusing into hot wine or beer. This is used to ease breathing and warm the ill person from chill.

Topical Use: Has good antibacterial activity for topical use as a wash or soak, made into a strong tea and used as a hair rinse for dandruff

Contraindications: Breastfeeding (unless intentional weaning is desired) Long term use of sage is very drying

Interesting Historical Facts and Folklore

Salvia comes from the Latin word meaning "to heal". From Culpeper's Herbal: 'The juice of Sage in warm water cureth hoarseness and cough. Sage is of excellent use to help the memory, warming and quickening the senses. The juice of Sage drunk with vinegar hath been of use in the time of the plague at all times. Gargles are made with Sage, Rosemary, Honeysuckles and Plantains, boiled in wine or water with some honey put thereto, to wash sore mouths and throats. Traditionally used to flavor pork sausages, but historical research back to Roman times indicates Sage's use as a valuable preservative of meat. In recent years the FDA has listed sage as a food preservative because of its high levels of antibacterial qualities.

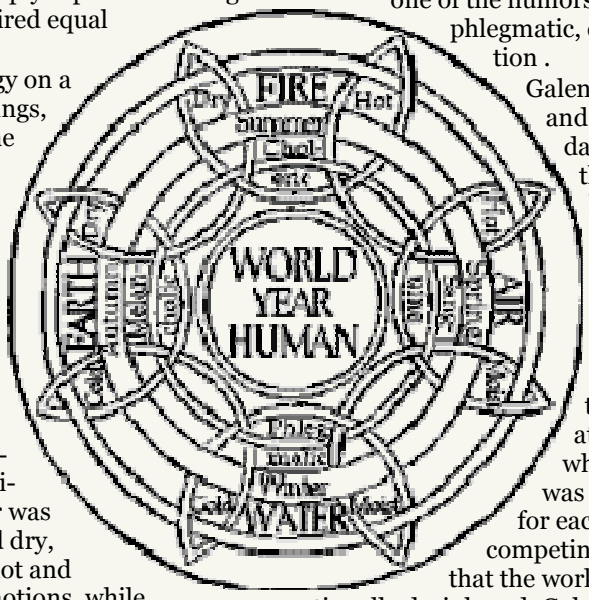
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Information researched and compiled by Susan Hess

Four Humors Medicine cont'd from page 10...

Galen's philosophical ideas – especially his four humors doctrine -- were predominantly inspired by Aristotle's natural philosophy. Aristotle's scheme rested on ideas first introduced to Greek culture by Empedocles of Acragas in Sicily, a philosopher physician who endeavored to explain to explain the genesis of life on earth through interaction of the four elements. Along with this ambitious undertaking, Empedocles claimed to be able to bring the dead back to life and exercise control over the weather. He developed a cosmology in which the universe was composed of fire, air, water and earth and ruled alternately by the forces of love and strife. When the influence of love was supreme, all the elements merged in an indistinguishable mass. When strife dominated, the elements were sharply separated. The generation of life in the universe required equal influence of both forces .



Plato built some of his ontology on a foundation of Empedoclean teachings, equating the four elements with the four qualities. From fire came heat, from earth came cold, air was dry and water damp. Some physicians in the Hippocratic tradition adopted similar notions of the elements and qualities. Later, Aristotle brought his intellect to bear on the relationship between the four elements and qualities. In contradiction with Plato, he asserted that the four elements actually derived from combinations of the four qualities: water was cold and moist, earth was cold and dry, fire was hot and dry, and air was hot and moist. Galen adopted Aristotle's notions, while "Hippocratically decorous doctors, who found rivals in philosophically inclined medical men, objected strongly to the doctrine that the fundamental principles of the world were the four elements and their paired qualities" .

With an underpinning of Aristotelian ideas, Galen linked the four elements with the four bodily fluids he deemed essential: blood, yellow bile, black bile and phlegm.

This association was aberrant in its time. Most physicians saw the body's fluids as "major indicators" and sometimes determinants of health and disease, but there was no consensus on the number or type of fluids, nor was there even consensus on the definition of phlegm, bile and other fluids across Greek literature . Galen chose blood, yellow bile, black bile, and phlegm from a text in the Hippocratic Corpus called On the Nature of Man, probably authored by Hippocrates' son-in-law, which mentions only these four. Instead of presenting a unified voice, the Corpus works authored by Hippocrates, his students and sons contradict each other in diagnostics and modes of therapy .

According to the Nature of Man, the mixture of essential fluids or humors determined the health of the individual and could be affected by diet and weather or climate . Humors, or fluids, "rose" in the body seasonally and upset the balance of the mixture, causing illness. The quantity of phlegm increases in the winter and causes "nasal discharges, white swellings, and phlegmy diseases" . As spring comes the influence of phlegm is still strong, but blood increases, having a nature akin to the season's warm, moist showers. Greeks observed the incidences of dysentery and nasal hemorrhages to increase at this time "when men are hot and red" . Yellow bile begins to dominate with summer's dry heat and increases until autumn. As the cold days of autumn settle in, the influence of blood is utterly diminished and yellow bile is replaced by black bile. In addition to the seasonal influences, each person must contend with their own personal temperament; their inherited tendency towards a dominance of one of the humors resulting in either a bilious, phlegmatic, choleric, or sanguine constitution .

Galen adopted these ideas as dogma and made them the universal standard. His guiding principle was the belief in the ordered, comprehensible nature of the human body and he organized all this medical information into the framework of the four Empedoclean elements. Galen believed that the human body had been assembled "by a deity very like the demiurge of Plato who created the world of the Timaeus" where reason reigned and order was maintained because strict roles for each element of society balanced competing . To dramatically demonstrate that the workings of the body could be rationally deciphered, Galen once deftly disabled the laryngeal nerve of a squealing pig in front of a stunned audience, silencing it without killing it .

Pre-Greek Pathology:
Putrefaction and the Paranormal

Medical historians usually hearken back to Greece when identifying the germ of western medicine. Hoever, notions of pathology espoused by Greeks from Hippocrates to Alcmaeon to Galen have their roots in eras past, especially in the mix of mysticism and rational scientific health care of the Egyptians.

A central medical contribution of the Egyptians was a unifying theory of disease etiology based on natural, internal causes and observation of scientific phenomena. Their treatment of the dead and their health care both developed from the same observation of physical reality: all organic substances eventually putrefy.

Western popular culture's fascination with mummies has made us familiar with the outlines of Egyptian embalming practice.

It is all about pulling the brain out through the nostrils, scooping the viscera into little jars, and bathing the body in a preservative chemical cocktail: essentially, chemically altering or removing organic substances which are destined to decay and render the body's outer shell less than perfect. The Egyptians postulated that for a living human with a body composed of organic matter, constantly consuming organic nutriment, putrefaction was an ever-present danger. Improper digestion left deleterious residues in the bowels. These residues corrupted and produced noxious gases or other secretions that could poison the body by "rising" from the lower bowel (Saunders 24). Egyptian physicians understood that these noxious agents could cause fever, formation and discharge of pus, and/or enter the blood/vascular system to travel throughout the body. If the noxious substances reached the blood, they had the potential to corrupt the very life fluid. This etiological theory engendered a therapeutic practice intended to rid the body of the "superfluities or residues" through emetics, purges and enemas. The purging of putrefying organic matter from the living mirrored the efforts of the priests who prepared the dead for eternal rest; thus, it should be no surprise that the Egyptian verb *sdwh* means both "to embalm" and "to treat" .

The decline of Egypt's powerful role in the Mediterranean coincided with the birth of natural philosophy and medical sciences in Greece. In the Saite period, Egypt experienced a seeming renaissance when their economy stabilized and the splendor of the pyramid-building eras of the Old and Middle Kingdom appeared to be returning. This second wind was actually the great civilization's dying breath, a breath that upon exhale traveled North across the Mediterranean to transfer a wealth of medical knowledge and tradition to an embryonic Greek society.

Ancient Greece: A Zoo of Pathological Theories

In Greece, humoral doctrines never displaced the theory of putrefactive residues. Both theories interacted with the pneumatist doctrine of the animating and pathenogenic properties of air to create a continuum of etiological interpretations in an environment of fierce speculation about the body's workings with little accurate anatomical information. If anatomy is the foundation of modern western allopathic medicine, then the Greeks laid no cornerstones in the Hippocratic era. Dissection was rarely practiced on spiritual grounds. Therefore, diagnostics and speculation about origins of pathology were based on an examination of the inputs and outputs of the human body and classifications of states of the structures and organs that could be externally sensed.

Each physician or healer constructed their diagnostic and therapeutic practices from a combination of these pathological theories. In Greek society, as the Western philosophical tradition was birthed and the force of reason more and more prized, there was an increasing divide between scientific medical practice and spiritual/magic healing. Temple medicine and medical science "were not rival or hostile traditions" but they were undeniably separate. However, even rational Greek medicine was creative and intuitive in its attempt to explain the functioning of a body that was still quite a mysterious thing.

The Cnidian school of medicine shows the most direct inheritance from the Egyptians. Cnidian physicians attributed diseases to "nutriments not discharged by the belly but left as residues which then rise to regions about the head". Herodicus, a gymnast who later became a doctor in the Cnidian school, elucidates an etiology which owes much to the Egyptians. He believed that if nutriment was ingested without previous exercise, it would wallow in the stomach and fail to be incorporated. Instead, this residue would create two liquids – one bitter and one acid -- which would proceed to act negatively on the body "according to their strength, their blending and the places where they occur, such as the head, the liver or the spleen". Incidentally, Herodicus was infamous for over exercising his patients .

Medical historians usually hearken back to Greece when identifying the germ of western medicine. However, notions of pathology espoused by Greeks from Hippocrates to Alcmaeon to Galen have their roots in eras past, especially in the mix of mysticism and rational scientific health care of the Egyptians.

According to the pneumatist doctrine, as formulated by Alcmaeon and others who followed him, breath was believed to communicate life to the body and consciousness to the mind. The soul of the individual is breathed in from the world soul which permeates the air. Thus, breath is the intelligence and health of the body. When it is trapped in its movement through the body or when it carries harmful qualities it can cause sickness. The author of Breaths, a book in the Hippocratic corpus, expounded upon the potency of air in determining the health of the human system. All living beings "participate in air" and the author thinks it likely that all disease arises from air.

For some Greek physicians and thinkers, belief in the pathological potency of air led to the correlation of seasonal change and weather with shifts in the dominance of certain bodily constituents, usually the essential fluids or humors. Yet another book in the Hippocratic corpus – Airs, Waters, and Places -- is dedicated to detailing the influences of geography and winds from different directions on the body's phlegm, blood, and other essential fluids.

Galen assigned responsibility for the development of the four humors doctrine to the medical school founded by Hippocrates on another Greek peninsula called Cos. Galen's reading of Hippocrates is a selective portrait drawn from portions of the Corpus that were amenable with his philosophy. Throughout the Hippocratic Corpus, there is no distinct under girding of elemental cosmology and a multitude of essential fluids are mentioned. The book chosen by Galen to compliment his Aristotelian natural philosophy describes just four fluids or humors, and though blood, phlegm, and the biles are the four that seem to be most prominent in the rest of the literature, calling Galen's formulation of four humors theory Hippocratic is inaccurate.

Four humors theory was not central to the medical practice of Hippocrates of Cos, though the Coan school had more accent on the importance of humors and pneuma in pathology than the Cnidian medical school

Continued on page 16...

Sacred Agreements *by Matthew Sicher*



Much of life, and many of our relationships are governed by agreements. We may make formal and written agreements, but also verbal agreements and promises. To intentionally enter into agreement, to forge a contract with another is an act of tremendous import. Social contracts are the axis around which a healthy community is based.

As with community-wide contracts and agreements, the strength of our individual relationships are influenced by the sanctity with which we treat these agreements. An agreement is sacred, when made in the full light of consciousness and with good faith. The trust that can develop between us when these sacred agreements are adhered to is the foundation upon which long term relationships are built. As these trusting relationships continue and deepen, a new and profound element may emerge, and that is faith. This may be faith in one another, faith in your self, faith in the potentials inherent in this life.

The basis of Braucherei is faith. Nowhere is the sanctity of agreement more clearly expressed than in the healing arts and medicine ways found at some point in *every* culture. Our dear tradition has been primarily an oral tradition. When prayers are passed on, they come with a caveat. As my first teacher in the Braucherei Weg said to me, "When you agree to be a Braucher, you enter into a contract with God."

When one is entrusted with the tools and spirit of Braucherei, it is also often accompanied by an ultimatum. As we have been trained as Brauchers, we have all heard of other practitioners "losing the Powwow". This means that someone who could previously powwow has lost the ability to do so. Sometimes this happens because the Braucher is inflicted with a grave or chronic illness. This is one way to lose the Powwow. However, one can also loose the ability by forgetting about or ignoring their contract with God. My practice is informed by both the sacred contracts I have made with my elders and teachers, and also my "contract with God".

To live a life of inspiration and integrity ought, I believe, be a goal of life for all of us. To live in such a way is the conscious goal, and a conscious necessity in the lives of those both practicing and experiencing traditional healing arts. In order to remain effective as a practitioner, it is essential that I remain attentive to my attitudes, beliefs, and assumptions in relation to my life on the Earth and the influence of the Holy Spirit in my life.

We all go through times of struggle and doubt, but it is my responsibility as a Braucher to not allow myself to become lost in these dramas, lest I lose sight of the light illuminating my every footstep. I may indeed undergo times of great struggle and angst, but I may not become spiritually lazy. The trials and tribulations of life are not to be ignored, because we are not thrust into an experience until we are ready for it (even if we may try to convince ourselves otherwise). But as one committed to walking a medicine path, I must not fall prey to the temptation of apathy, to the life of ennui. Should I forget this, my sacred commitment to attention; I risk losing sight of my connection with Divinity. I risk losing the Powwow.

Braucherei, like most other traditional healing arts, has gone through many phases. Over the past several decades Braucherei has not only had a diminished presence in our community, but has also been intentionally ignored or shunned by some people. Because of this fact, many Brauchers have been conspicuously quiet over the years about their practice. At this time, there are still those who are not in support of the practice, but in general our community has undergone a change in perspective.

The practice as a whole is not seen with such inherent suspicion today, and so we have a greater ability to openly speak of it. This presents us with a unique situation in relation to our agreements in relation to our practice. Because Brauchers of the past generation or two did not openly speak of the practice, and that was assumed, there are not specific instructions as to how we are to speak about Braucherei. We have been unanimously told not to discuss the prayers, and some techniques within the practice, and of course, we unfailingly honor that sacred agreement.

However, we have reflected extensively on what rules of conduct are to govern our speaking *about* the practice. This is a perfect example of the continuing evolution that a practice must undergo in order to stay alive. A fine line is to be walked between tradition and innovation, and each of us must find our own ways of walking that tight rope. This is a balance to be struck within a family, in one's work, and in the myriad considerations that go into raising our children and thinking about the world in which our grandchildren will live.

...continued on next page...

...Sacred Agreements... continued from previous page:

In the practice of Braucherei, our method of addressing these considerations have been three-fold. In the first part as practitioners we individually sit and reflect. This is to be sure that our practice is in line both with our understanding of ourselves, and our relationship with the Holy Spirit. We talk amongst ourselves as current practitioners, to ensure that we are helping each other to grow as a part of a "Raad" or community of practitioners. And we air our questions with all of our teachers, to be sure that their role continues to be felt and acknowledged.

Dennis Boyer has been an invaluable elder and teacher to our Kutzeschteddel Raad (Kutztown Wheel). It is primarily through his research, interviews, and teachings that we have been able to recover the traditional ways of Braucherei as much as we have. I spoke with him about the ethics surrounding the sharing of Braucherei beliefs and practices with the public, seeking some guidance in this matter. He approved of the ways with which we have held the tradition thus far, and offered four points of wisdom to add to the mixture:

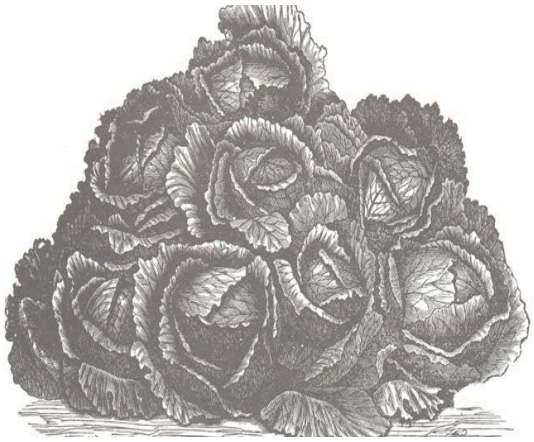
First and foremost, Dennis spoke of the need to keep an openness to and guidance from Spirit. He said that this is what allows us to understand that we are all conduits for spirit to move through, not repositories in which it resides. Second, he encouraged an openness to learning. He reminded me that this tradition is one with a long history of open minds. In accordance with this history it is important to recognize that wisdom might come from any source or direction, and should be welcomed when it comes. His third recommendation was to always operate from a position of love. It is only from within the Circle of Love that we can come to the harmonious place needed in healing work. Last he taught that we must respect our fellow journeyers on the Braucherei Weg. Here he cautioned that heedfulness to our own inner guidance should not calcify into orthodoxy.

The agreements and considerations involved in Braucherei are myriad. As in so many ways, Braucherei seems a microcosm of the rest of our life considerations. We must, all of us, focus on gaining ever-increasing clarity as to the nature of our sacred contracts. Life is truly a fine balancing act, with demands and considerations at every turn.

I have come to greatly value these lessons from our elders and teachers regarding ethics. Among the most reassuring, yet challenging lessons is that we all must find our own relationships with the information and people around which our lives revolve. And so I end this article wishing all of you well in this, the pursuit of your life's lessons. May clarity, understanding, and inner guidance come easily to you in times of need.

If you eat sausage on New Year's, you will be robust all year!

The PA German dialect translation on page 5



In the Deitsch home it is traditional to serve pork and sauerkraut on New Year's Day. Cabbage represents financial stability and abundance in the fields. As for the pork...well, pigs, root forward with their snouts. Chickens and other fowl scratch backwards with their feet. So the idea of eating pork and cabbage on the first day of the year sets the tone of moving forward in life (rather than backwards) and to be blessed with abundance and wealth in the coming year.

Four Humors Medicine...continued from page 13...

Instead, Hippocrates' central contributions to medicine include a practice of rigorous clinical observation with a degree of detail that, even in our time, "moves medical men to admiration" Hippocrates understood the importance of healthy daily regimen in the maintenance of good health. Proper sleep, daily exercise, hygiene, and a bland diet were some of the central prescriptions of this doctor, often hailed as the patriarch of our Western medicine. Hippocrates "charted the courses of diseases through their critical days" and condensed his practical experience into a series of succinct medical axioms such as "opposites cure opposites", found in the Corpus book Breaths. Galen believed Hippocrates' "opposites" referred to Aristotle's elementary qualities. This axiom became known as the Law of Hippocrates in the Middle Ages and the practice of curing with contraries became known as allopathic medicine.

Not all medical minds classify pathological information the same way and the Greek medical ethos was infused with a menagerie of humoral doctrines. For Alcmaeon, the first to speak of the humors as bodily constituents, health was achieved when the influence of each fluid was balanced and disease indicated that one held unwarranted dominance. He believed that the human body was analogous to a governmental body and simply applied his political observations in his doctrine of bodily health.

The physician Praxagoras declared he had discovered eleven humors distinct from the traditional four. He named these fluids, presumably encountered in his visits with his Grecian patients, the "sweet, the uniformly mixed, the glassy, the acid, the nitrous, the salty, the bitter, the leek-green, the yolk-colored, the corrosive, and the clotting". Praxagoras attempted to correlate the abundance of one of these humors in the body with the kind of food ingested. It is unclear what fluids Praxagoras was actually observing.

Other Greek physicians, a man named Thrasymachus of Sardis among them, maintained that temperature change could provoke blood to transform to phlegm, pus, or bile. Diocles had reason to believe that phlegm cooled and compacted the blood, whereas the rowdy influence of bile could cause it to boil and curdle.

Other pathological understandings were born where putrefaction theories and humoralism overlapped. Some Greeks understood putrefaction as a *qualitative* change in one of the fluids or humors of the body, contrary to the more popular idea that the pathenogenic humor was merely in excessive abundance. Even Galen spoke ambivalently about the manner in which the four fluids cause illness. He differentiated "between a superabundance of humors constituting a plentitude and a qualitative change in the humor constituting a cacochymia", or putrefaction of chyme. The Greek concept of a "flux" occurring in one of the body's fluids also echoes the Egyptian idea of the "rising" of a bodily fluid or a gas from putrefaction.

Some believed the humors caused disease when blocked from normal flow, or when they caused a blockage, when they interacted with each other, when they overflowed, when temperature changed, or when they changed in quantity or quality. Clearly, the unified humoral doctrine is a mythical creature. Instead, a plethora of theories ran wild in ancient Greece. The merit in the exploration of these older theories of pathology lies especially in provoking us to be creative and avoid dogmatism in the work to revive the Braucherei tradition and to continue exploration of our own intuition.

Twelve Days ... continued from page 9...

The "9 ladies dancing" were the 9 truths of the Holy Spirit (Gal. 5): Love, Joy, Peace, Longsuffering, Kindness, Goodness, Faithfulness, Gentleness, Self-Control

The "10 Lords a leaping" referred to the 10 Commandments.

The "11 pipers piping" recalled the 11 faithful apostles of Jesus: Simon (who is called Peter), Andrew, James son of Zebedee, John, Philip, Bartholomew, Thomas, Matthew, James son of Alphaeus, Thaddaeus, and Simon the Zealot. This excludes Judas Iscariot, the betrayer.

The "12 drummers drumming" symbolized the 12 points of belief in the Apostle Creed.

I believe in God the Father Almighty, Maker of Heaven and earth.

and in Jesus Christ, His only Son, our Lord

who was conceived by the Holy Spirit, born of the virgin Mary,

suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died, and was buried: He descended into Hell:

the third day He rose again from the dead.

He ascended into Heaven,

and sits at the right hand of God the Father Almighty.

From thence He shall come to judge the living and the dead.

I believe in the Holy Spirit,

one holy Christian Church, the fellowship of saints,

the forgiveness of sins,

the resurrection of the body, and the life everlasting.

Surely the original song from the original tune reflected points of faith and tradition of pre-Christian northern Europeans, but after attempting to find such a song, I came up with very little. This song obviously reflects a later, Medieval Christian culture, and one that butted heads strongly with the leaders of the reformation, but one that lives on strongly in Braucherei tradition, nonetheless.

Urglaawe continued from page 8...

While a great many Americans are familiar with hex signs, they may not recognize some of the ancient symbols (the Rain Hex sign features a swastika, for example) that give these symbols power. This is a very visible Heathen remnant that is widely spread within Pennsylvania German culture.

We are told, as the story often goes, that hex signs are 'chust for nice', yet, in my experience, even many Christians are choosy about which symbols they put on their barns or homes. Some Urglaawer are very actively engaged in studying symbols described in works by earlier Hexologists like Lee Gandee. Their dedication to expanding the awareness and use of symbols in daily and shamanic practices is generating a new respect for the old symbols in the practice of Urglaawe.



'Freya' by Johannes Gehrts 1901

Urglaawer are also fortunate to have access to several herbal experts who either count themselves as Urglaawer or who are helping us to connect with Pennsylvania German plant lore. Indeed, herbs are already incorporated into Braucherei and Hexerei, and many families, including Christian Plain Folk (Amish, Mennonite, Brethren, etc.), regularly use natural remedies alongside of more modern cures. Herbal use is thus another living tradition, and it has incorporated information from other cultures, including Amerindian knowledge. This evolution is to be expected as we encounter new plant species from around the world.

These living traditions are relatively easy for Urglaawer to tap into. What is more difficult is locating older information and processing it properly. We are currently in the early stages of what we expect to be a very long process. We can learn from the same sources as our German Heathen cousins up until approximately 1683, when Pennsylvania German settlement began and our distinct tribal experiences commenced. Thus, we can learn much of our heritage from works like Grimms *Teutonic Mythology*. What happened after emigration from the German lands is a bit more difficult.

One challenge has been access to old lore outside of the usual Braucherei and Hexerei materials. Documents from the Colonial and Early Republic periods in Deitsch or in German are frequently hard to find or are in fragile condition. Also, since the bulk of the Pennsylvania Germans were of ardent Christian faith, references to Heathen activity often are scorned or denounced as Satanic, etc., so the Urglaawer still have much work ahead of us as we investigate our lore heritage.

A prime example of the importance of perspective in lore is Hexenkopf in Northampton County, PA. Much of the oral and written materials view this mountain pillar as being haunted or bewitched. Furthermore, the folklore from the region included references to activity being particularly strong on Walpurgisnacht (see *Hexenkopf: History, Healing & Hexerei* by Ned Heindel).

A group of Urglaawer got permission from the landowners to visit Hexenkopf during the winter, and the consensus among us was that it is a spiritual place sacred to Haerrin Freya und Haerrin Holle. Thus, a place that is associated with witchcraft in a negative connotation in Christianity becomes a splendid and positive location in which to honor our Gods and Goddesses. This sensation carried through to our Sege (blot) at the site to the two Goddesses on Walpurgisnacht.

Urglaawer have grown to hold Hexenkopf as sacred, and we will continue to hold ceremonies there and to seek curative water pools that are cited in the lore surrounding the mountain pillar. Hexenkopf is but one example of several references in our lore that we need to research and explore. Hopefully we will find many more bits of information in other texts that will lead us down new paths. We have a huge task ahead of us and we are just at the beginning. We are very eager to learn more about our hidden heritage, and we welcome others who are interested us to join us in our pursuits!

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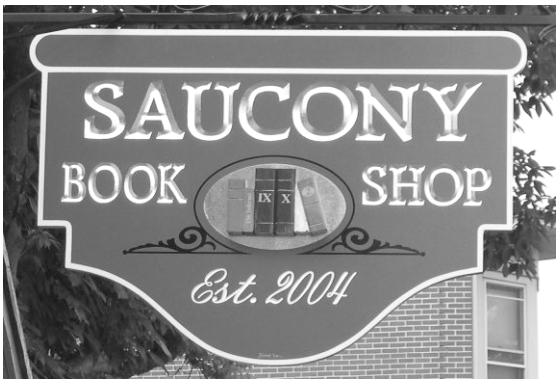
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'Hollerbeier Haven' Guild Gatherings in Kutztown, PA

February 28, 2009 - "Barn Stars and Hex Signs" "Chust for nice"? Or full of meaning? Patrick Donmoyer will explore the sacred symbols behind the hex signs of southeastern PA. Patrick has done extensive and unprecedented research on barn artwork and sacred symbolism in Deitsch culture. In 2008 Patrick undertook a project to document all of the hex signs and much of the other barn decoration of Berks county. He has been touted by many longtime scholars as the new expert in Hex Sign symbolism and history. During this workshop Patrick will share his knowledge of such symbolism, and share some ways to incorporate these symbols into our own lives and homes.

March 28, 2009 - Wheel of the Year Part 1 Our March gathering will focus on the Light half of the year, from Walpurgisnacht (May Eve) to Alleliebeziel (Halloween). Jesse Tobin will be sharing information about the Yaahrraad, which comes predominantly out of the Oley Braucherei Freindschaft. She will focus on the major and minor feasts acknowledged in the Braucherei tradition during this part of the year. In addition to this she will explore the significance of each of the six moons, of this half of the year. Jesse will discuss the significance of each moon from the perspective of the Greek Zodiac and the Oley-Pikeville moon Calendar.

April 25, 2009 – En Deitsches Medizinraad The medicine wheel of the Deitsch people is a unique combination of many cultural influences: Greek, Jewish, Germanic, and Native American as well as many others. This has created a unique perspective in healing, as well as folklore surrounding the medicine wheel that is particular to Deitsch culture. Annie Hasz spent much of her time in the Braucherei Weg course studying the evolution of this medicine wheel, and its Greek Four Humors medical base in particular. She will share information about the evolution and use of this wheel in modern Braucherei practice.

***NEW LOCATION! All Gatherings will be held at the Indigo Natural Healing Center on Rt 222 (15525 Kutztown Rd, Kutztown, PA 19530) on the last Saturday of the month from 10-3pm (unless otherwise noted) $35 members/$45 non-members. To register call Jesse at 484-336-4611 or email her at Thr3Sisters@aol.com**

'Herbal Hands Workshops" in Pottstown, PA

February 7 th , 2009 10– 12:30: Let's Make Soft Cheese! It's so easy to make soft cheese with farm-fresh cow or goat milk and culture. We will go through the simple steps of making a fresh cheese like Chevre' or Fromage Blanc. Unlike cheese that needs to be aged and carefully tended for months, fresh cheeses are ready to eat within two days and can be easily incorporated into any kitchen routine using=2 0basic kitchen equipment. After the basics are discussed and demonstrated, we will get our hands pleasantly 'dirty' by rolling freshly made cheese into fresh chopped herbs and toasted almonds. At the end of the class we will taste a variety of cheeses with crackers. Informational handouts and resource list included. The cost for this class is $50 and will include a copy of Ricki Carroll's Book "Home Cheese Making" and one packet of culture of your choice. Register early…this class has been wildly popular!

Saturday, March 7th 2009 10-3 pm: Dreaming the Herbal Garden Use the winter months wisely by creating a thorough spring and summer garden plan now! We will discuss: defining your vision, basics of garden design, overview of annual and perennial herbs, resources for research, planning, seeds and herb plants. Part of this class will be structured for sharing and inspiration so please come with your specific questions and ideas, seed catalogs, gardening magazines, sketches & photos, if you have them. You'll go home with abundant handouts, a checklist for garden planning to work on at home and a small herb garden journal to organize all of your ideas.

Saturday, April 4th 2009 10-3 pm: Spring House Cleaning- Natural Ways to Clean your Home on Every Level! By simple blending of inexpensive household ingredients, essential oils and herbs we can easily create a wide variety of non- toxic cleaning products that are healthy for humans, pets and the environment. We will also discuss various ways to cleanse your body and space of psychic 'dirt', how to create sacred space, clearing ideas for moving into or out of a home, and 'clearing the air' after a disagreement. Vow to give your home a thorough cleaning this spring! Resource materials, supplies list and recipes will be provided. We will also make some products to take home.

*** All Herbal Hands Workshops will be held at the Farm at Coventry on the first Saturday of the month from 10-3pm and cost $40 (unless otherwise noted) . To register call Susan at 610-469-9591 or visit www.FarmatCoventry.com to register online**

Three Sisters Center
for the Healing Arts
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19529

Visit our newly updated website ! www.ThreeSistersCenter.com

"If homespun is to wear well,
There should be no spinning between Christmas
and New Years Day"

From "Beliefs and Superstitions of the Pennsylvania Germans"
by Edwin Miller Fogel

